COUNTRY REPORTS: BENIN

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Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The 2026-2033 programme of the Wadagni–Talata ticket promises every administrative procedure online by 2030, public services fully online by 2033 and a law on data localisation, the newest layer on a strategy stack that keeps growing.

Strategy itself has been continuous. The National Artificial Intelligence and Big Data Strategy 2023-2027 was adopted in January 2023, a strategic vision for 2031 was drafted in February 2026 as the successor to the 2021-2026 government digital plan, and Smart Africa sought consultants in November 2025 to write a national data strategy. The 2021 Sectoral Policy Statement covers universal access alongside cybersecurity, data centres and cloud, and data protection. Against that, the GovTech and digital transformation strategy is recorded as old and due to be updated (2025).

Ownership is clear at the top and thin below it. The whole-of-government approach is institutionalised and led by a designated ministry, but there is no cross-government forum at which senior digital officials work across departments, and reporting on progress is internal and unpublished (2025), and there is no coordination body steering GovTech and no entity tracking digital spending across government. A data governance body exists but sits inside another institution, its strategy is in progress rather than adopted, and it publishes no report on its results or spending (2025). Cloud is the clearest hole: there is no shared cloud platform for government entities and no hosting policy (2025).

The agency running the estate frames the remaining task the same way. ASIN's director general puts the difficulty at governance and coherence across infrastructure already built rather than at further construction, and is drafting a national DPI roadmap around a "once-only" principle (July 2026). The newest instrument shows the gap between announcement and delivery: a joint circular of 24 July 2026 requires every state structure to move archive and procedure management onto digital tools, yet the government's announcement of it states no deadline, budget line, definition of the documents in scope or compliance mechanism.

Legislation and regulation

The most recent change to Benin's binding digital law widened who the state counts: in June 2025 the National Assembly amended article 6 of the identification law to bring foreigners and Afro-descendants granted Beninese nationality by recognition into the biometric register, creating a residents file for foreigners and a distinct identification number for each category.

It amends a base that is unusually consolidated for the region. The Digital Code, Law No. 2017-20 of 2018, is a single statute covering broadband internet, cybersecurity, data centres and cloud services, data protection, digital identification, digital payments, electronic signatures and e-commerce, and it is revised rather than supplemented: Law No. 2020-35 of 6 January 2021 amended its Book V on personal data, which sits alongside the older Law No. 2009-09 of 22 May 2009 and carries the rights and the supervisory authority described below. Identity is the exception, with its own statute: Law No. 2017-08 of 19 June 2017 governs the identification of natural persons, the personal identification number and the national population register, and created ANIP. Government data exchange is organised by decree under the code — Decree No. 2020-209 of 18 March 2020 for the interoperability framework and Decree No. 2022-324 of 1 June 2022 creating ASIN to operate it — and that framework binds private bodies providing a public service as well as public ones.

The code's most contested provision is its offence of harassment through electronic communications: prosecutors sought a two-year sentence against a journalist under Article 550 in May 2026 over two Facebook posts, the 2023 Universal Periodic Review recommended reforming it, and a parliamentary workshop in November 2024 weighed defining the offence and adding a prior-notice procedure, but no amendment has been made.

Tax law is where the sector has most recently been reached: Benin levies a 1 per cent tax on large cash payments, and the 2026 amending finance bill proposed further taxation of the digital economy (June 2026).

The codified stack is narrow. Three instruments carry almost all of it — the 2018 Digital Code, the 2021 Sectoral Policy Statement and the 2023-2027 AI and Big Data Strategy — while most of the specialised areas an inventory would look for have no standalone instrument of their own, among them spectrum policy, infrastructure sharing, e-waste, critical information infrastructure protection, open banking, a startup act and an AI law. Where the code is silent, so is the statute book. The audiovisual regulator signed conventions with 89 online radio, television and press outlets on 1 October 2026, closing its authorisation process for online media.

Data protection

Benin's data protection authority is doing enforcement work, not just existing: the APDP examined 907 compliance files in 2025 and validated 87.4 per cent of them, carried out 64 control missions, issued 75 conformity certificates and recorded 37 designated data protection officers, and took 14 major cases to its litigation session, some ending in fines. Its 2025 activity report, one of a published series, records 782 control and litigation cases and 20 privacy complaints instructed. The capacity behind that work has just been enlarged: seventeen officers were sworn in on 14 September 2026. It is staffing rather than enforcement — no case, sanction or inspection figure accompanies it.

The regime it enforces is statutory. Personal data protection is governed by the law of 6 January 2021 within the Digital Code, which establishes the APDP as supervisory authority, with rights of access, rectification, objection, portability and erasure. The APDP is an independent administrative authority with legal personality; it supervises processing, investigates breaches and issues sanctions, including over the biometric identification system, and its decisions may be appealed to the competent administrative jurisdiction. Article 427 of the Digital Code requires every controller to notify the authority and the affected data subject without delay of a breach and its likely consequences. No data localisation requirement applies to personal or other data (2024).

Transfers abroad are cleared one controller at a time: the APDP's published deliberations authorise named transfers, nine in 2021 alone, among them employee and client data sent to France and Morocco, survey data to Canada and nutrition-project data to Germany and Kenya. The regulator also sits inside the plumbing: a private body connecting to the national data exchange must obtain APDP authorisation before its first connection, and exchanges run under conventions naming the data, the purposes and the security measures.

The sharpest current exposure is inside government itself. ASIN's June 2026 legal note on generative AI records that public agents already use such tools on personal accounts, outside any formalised framework, and calls for a census of those users so they can be moved to secured arrangements. It recommends provider contracts carrying a data-processing agreement and clauses forbidding any use of administration data to train or optimise models, and a contractual bar on transferring that data to extraterritorial jurisdictions — though ASIN concludes that residual risks to digital sovereignty and technological dependence remain.

Cooperation is being built outwards: the APDP and Senegal's data protection commission signed a cooperation convention in Cotonou in April 2026, and at an international data protection forum in Lomé in July 2026 it set out Benin's compliance work and pressed for stronger cooperation between African authorities.

Décret 2024-877 of 11 April 2024 sets the rules for ten criminal-justice files, including DNA and biometric data, with retention of 10 and 30 years, no right to object and appeal to the data protection authority. The regional police information programme's newsletter of December 2024 records the decree.

Regional collaboration

The regional digital agenda Benin signs up to is not paid for by the region: ECOWAS's Community Budget 2026-2028 carries no disaggregated digital or ICT appropriation, and its only ICT-named programme line records nil spending from 2023 and none in the estimates to 2028, so the instruments Benin relies on are externally financed.

Benin nonetheless convenes more of the agenda than most of its neighbours. It hosted the West and Central Africa digital transformation summit in Cotonou in November 2025, at which ministers of the two regions adopted a declaration committing to a single digital market built on interoperable digital public infrastructure and 90% affordable broadband coverage by 2030, and to harmonising their cybersecurity, data governance and artificial intelligence frameworks. A year earlier, the ECOWAS Digital Sector Development Strategy 2024-2029 was adopted at Cotonou, and the same meeting required member states to have the ECOWAS Roaming Regulation fully implemented by all mobile operators by the end of 2025. Benin adopted shared AI governance guidelines with five other francophone West African states, submitted to the UN Global AI Dialogue (July 2026), joined the 50-in-5 campaign in 2026, and has pledged to implement both the Malabo and Budapest Conventions.

What crosses the border is narrower than what has been declared. The physical biometric identity card, issued to international civil aviation standards, lets Beninese travel across ECOWAS (2020), but the digital layer above it does not run on ECOWAS machinery: the ECOWAS-World Bank WURI programme has validated a cross-border interoperability strategy and a 2026 work plan for mutual recognition of credentials, not an operating service, while the one arrangement that does carry credentials across a border reaches outside the region — Smart Africa has launched a cross-border digital identity pilot between Rwanda, Ghana and Benin, with eighteen more countries said to be joining — and Burkina Faso, Mali and Niger, which severed their ties with ECOWAS in 2024, are rolling out an identity card of their own bloc. Payments do cross, on infrastructure the region owns: the BCEAO operates the WAEMU clearing and settlement systems Benin uses, and its instant payment rail opened to the public in September 2025, with connection deadlines still running into 2027. Regional Integration is one of Benin's ten most improved governance indicators, at 65.9 out of 100 in 2023 and 3rd of 54 after a 24.7-point rise over the decade. The Beninese and Togolese data-protection authorities held a joint working session at Lome on 2 and 3 October 2026 under their cooperation agreement.

Standards

Benin publishes how badly its own institutions meet its security standard: compliance with the state information-system security policy ranges from 6 per cent to 87 per cent across public institutions (2021-2024), published by the state in the first national report on the vulnerabilities of Beninese cyberspace, published in June 2025.

The interoperability framework is the main standard-setting instrument, and specific where such documents are vague. It sets four levels — juridical, organisational, semantic and technical — with governance running across all of them, presents itself as recommendations while obliging public and private administrations providing a public service to observe its principles, and names the standards it requires rather than gesturing at them, citing W3C specifications including WCAG 2.0 for accessibility, ISO 10918, ISO/IEC 26300, MPEG4 and named RFCs. Around it sit a data quality framework, uptime monitoring of government information systems and guidance for replacing legacy systems (2025), and access conditions published in July 2026 requiring registration in the interoperability catalogue, demonstrated data governance and conformity to API and web-service standards.

Elsewhere the mandating is patchier. Benin has a unified budget classification and chart of accounts covering central government, and its financial management system exchanges data both through separate interfaces and through a government service bus (2025), and land records run on the e-Foncier Bénin land information system, built to the ISO 19152 standard (2023). Procurement does not enforce standards on its own data: the e-procurement portal publishes tender notices and contracts but not to the Open Contracting Data Standard, and does not exchange data with other government systems (2025). There is no government open source software policy or action plan for the public sector (2025).

Newer standards are arriving as guidance rather than as framework. ASIN's June 2026 legal note on generative AI calls for a binding harmonised charter setting the roles of public-service staff, providers and partners alike. On method, ASIN has given state security officers a common risk-analysis framework in EBIOS Risk Manager, and the certification programme for those officers, taught to Certified Ethical Hacker and ISO 27001, is presented as part of implementing the national digital security strategy and the state information-system security policy.

The state digital agency presented a national cybersecurity reference framework for AI systems to the administration's information-systems directors on 8 October 2026: four risk tiers from minimal to unacceptable, an AI officer and an ethics committee, and traceability of system decisions.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Journalists are being prosecuted over what they post online. The economic and terrorism court, the CRIET, sentenced journalist Pascal Mitowadé on 24 March 2026 to five years and a XOF 10 million fine over a social-media post made during the December 2025 coup attempt; prosecutors sought two years, one of them firm, against Angela Kpeïdja under Article 550 of the Digital Code in May 2026 over two Facebook posts; and editor Olivier Allochémé was held in pre-trial detention from 16 October 2025 for publishing false news on social media. The Committee to Protect Journalists wrote to President Wadagni on 1 September 2026, 100 days into his term, asking that Article 550 no longer be used against the press.

Consultation is where Benin's governance record has fallen furthest: Deliberative and Participatory Governance is its fifth most deteriorated indicator, down 30.6 points over 2014-2023 to 49.2 out of 100 and 34th of 54, and Public Perception of Freedom of Speech is the fourth most deteriorated, down 32.7 points to 53.5. Both fell while the formal position held: Freedom of Expression and Belief remains one of the country's ten best-scoring indicators at 90.2 out of 100, 5th of 54, and Digital Freedom stood at 80.7, 9th of 54. What people feel able to say has moved faster than what the law allows.

The channels exist and terminate. National platforms let citizens and businesses take part in policy decision-making and accept anonymous submissions, but take no petitions, and the government's responses are not published (2025); separate platforms take complaints and information requests, support users with disabilities and carry published service standards (2025). But the government does not demonstrate that it changes services in the light of the

feedback it receives (2025), and right-to-information legislation is in force while nothing is published on how it is working (2025). Accountability and Transparency is one of Benin's three worst-scoring governance sub-categories at 47.6 out of 100 in 2023, down 5.0 points over the decade.

Argument about digital policy happens largely outside the state's channels. Benin hosted the West Africa Feminist Data Summit in Porto-Novo in July 2026, convened by the Réseau des femmes leaders pour le développement on decolonising data, with tracks on digital censorship and shutdowns, technology-facilitated gender-based violence and press freedom, which produced policy briefs naming regulatory gaps alongside a regional feminist data agenda for 2026-2028. It adopted the Déclaration de Porto-Novo as a common reference framework for the region's feminist movements, and sat inside Nafasi, a Sida-funded continental programme running 2026-2029 to preserve the space in which civil society, journalists and women human rights defenders operate. Press capacity is growing: journalists were trained in Cotonou in March 2026 on biometric identity and personal data protection. Locally, grievances are concrete: access to civil-status records was under open dialogue in Godomey in June 2026.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Benin has begun working out how its identity agency will pay its own way: the World Bank-financed WURI project opened recruitment in September 2026 for an international expert to define a sustainable business model for ANIP, with a roadmap covering the financing, operation, maintenance and modernisation of its infrastructure and services, while the WURI-2 operation that finances the agency runs to 2027.

National resources carry 71.8% of the digital lines of the 2026 finance law at the appropriation stage, XOF 19.9 billion of XOF 27.8 billion, against 63.2% in 2025 and 73.7% in 2024; in each year the external side is chiefly a loan tranche on the digital programme, XOF 10.0 billion in 2025 and XOF 6.5 billion in 2026.

The 2026 tranche is a World Bank loan for phase 2 of the national high- and very-high-speed internet project, alongside XOF 1.24 billion of the state's own money on the same activity (2026), and the same programme puts XOF 2.0 billion of budget money into the digital transformation of local authorities as capital transfers (2026). What is voted is largely spent on the domestic side: by 31 December 2025 the digital programme's own capital had been ordonnanced at XOF 6.61 billion against XOF 6.24 billion voted, while its loan tranche reached XOF 4.65 billion of XOF 10.04 billion and the digital ministry's support programme 52.8% (2025).

Own-source money reaches the estate through a special allocation account. The account for modernising the revenue administrations is voted XOF 6.0 billion a year from earmarked revenue, and it took in XOF 4.08 billion in 2024; in 2025 it ordonnanced XOF 1.86 billion, 31.1% of its vote.

MoUs and other agreements

Benin adopted shared AI governance guidelines with Burkina Faso, Côte d'Ivoire, Guinea, Mali and Senegal, submitted to the UN Global AI Dialogue (July 2026), the newest of a set of instruments that commit the country to a position rather than to a sum.

The others are of the same kind. The Cotonou Declaration of November 2025 sets its West and Central African signatories digital-skills and employment targets as regional totals and calls on each to adopt a national digital compact by 2028. Benin's data protection authority signed a cooperation convention with Senegal's Commission de protection des données personnelles in Cotonou in April 2026, and the country joined the 50-in-5 digital public infrastructure campaign in 2026 as its sixteenth African member, represented by the digital agency ASIN.

New investments

Benin is one of three beneficiary countries of WARDIP2, a USD 137 million World Bank-financed regional programme announced on 11 March 2026 to fund broadband and digital public services across Benin, Liberia and Sierra Leone, having been absent from the borrowers of the programme's first tranche, a USD 266 million operation whose borrowers are The Gambia, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau and Mauritania. The West African Development Bank agreed to lend XOF 19.5 billion, about USD 32 million, over 2026-2027 to digitalise the Ministry of Economy and Finance, covering the ministry's data centre, the post office's information system and the development-finance and HR systems (May 2026).

Fifteen distinct digital-sector financing commitments to Benin are on record as at August 2026, spanning 2015 to 2030, twelve of them Benin-specific and three regional West Africa operations. They come to around USD 770 million in announced value as at August 2026, around USD 320 million of it committed to Benin alone; the rest sits in regional totals covering four to seven countries. Eleven financiers appear, led by the World Bank with three commitments and China Eximbank and Germany's BMZ with two each. Grants are the most common instrument, at eight of the fifteen, but the loans carry the larger sums, and connectivity takes the largest share of the money. Four of the fifteen were announced in 2026 alone, more than in any earlier year.

The largest single commitment reaching Benin is WURI-2, a USD 273 million World Bank operation running 2020-2027 under which Benin borrows alongside Burkina Faso, Niger and Togo to expand foundational digital ID. The largest Benin-specific one is the Digital Rural Transformation Project, USD 100 million over 2019-2025, for digital agriculture, rural broadband and financial inclusion. Older money is Chinese: China Eximbank signed a CNY 496 million concessional loan on 7 April 2015, on 20-year terms with a 7-year grace period at 2 per cent, for the Cotonou-Malanville fibre backbone, then financed a second phase densifying the network. Maroc Telecom's EUR 150 million West Africa submarine cable lands at Cotonou and has been fully in service since April 2022. Germany's BMZ funds BenInnovation, EUR 6.5 million over 2022-2026 on structuring the digital sector.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The network now passes most of the country while most people are still not on it: 4G population coverage reached 88 per cent in 2024, up from 62 per cent in 2020, against an estimated 34.0 per cent of the population using the internet in early 2023, around 4.6 million people. Unique mobile subscribers numbered 8.5 million at the end of 2023, a penetration rate of 67 per cent, and entry-level mobile data cost more in 2022 than the international affordability threshold. The regulator counted 55,199 fixed internet subscriptions at 30 June 2025, a 0.42 per cent penetration, and 10.6 million active mobile internet subscriptions, down from 12.4 million at the end of 2024, 22 per cent of them held by women.

Benin's IIAG Mobile Communications score rose 26.7 points over 2014-2023 to 69.6 out of 100, 24th of 54, while Internet and Computers stood at 34.6 out of 100 in 2023, also 24th of 54, after a 17.4-point rise. Infrastructure remains the country's worst-scoring IIAG sub-category at 42.3 out of 100 in 2023, 21st of 54, despite the second-largest decadal gain of its 16 sub-categories. Public opinion runs ahead of the measurement: the Public Perception of Infrastructure score rose 41.4 points to 62.0 out of 100 in 2023, 8th of 54.

The backbone is externally financed; the domestic exchange layer is thin. Chinese concessional lending funded the first phase of the National Broadband Network Project — rehabilitation of the Cotonou-Malanville fibre backbone, a Cotonou metropolitan loop, followed by a densification phase implemented by the Agence du Numérique, and the West Africa submarine cable lands at Cotonou, fully in service since April 2022. A terrestrial route from Lagos to

Accra through Benin and Togo was activated in May 2025, built with the state infrastructure company SBIN after the March 2024 subsea cable failures. Benin-IX in Cotonou, established in December 2013, is still the only operational internet exchange point, with a small number of local networks participating alongside international peering nodes.

Access remains uneven, with a persistent digital divide acknowledged by the digital minister as the 2031 strategic vision was drafted (February 2026). Subscription is now tied to identity: the regulator ordered unregistered SIM cards deactivated from 30 April 2025. ECOWAS ministers meeting at Cotonou in October 2024 required all mobile operators to implement the regional roaming regulation by the end of 2025, and Benin is one of three beneficiaries of the World Bank's WARDIP2 programme, announced in March 2026 to fund broadband and digital public services.

Data Storage

Benin's public estate runs from a single site, and is now looking for a second: the national data centre at Abomey-Calavi, operated by the state-owned SBIM, is to be backed by a redundant site, possibly elsewhere in West Africa, for which a World Bank-funded project sought a feasibility study in March 2026. An official of the state digital agency put the country's data centres at several sites, one of them Tier III, with about 2 MW of capacity in all and under-used (April 2026). Behind them there is no shared platform: as at 2025 there was no cloud platform available to all government entities, no government cloud hosting policy, and nothing published on government cloud usage, security or savings. The national artificial intelligence and big data strategy plans to equip the data centre with cloud and AI-as-a-service capability for hosting public-sector systems, and the West African Development Bank is financing modernisation and redundancy of the finance ministry's own data centre over 2026-2027.

Commercial hosting in country is operator-run: MTN Benin rents servers and hosting space in its own data centre to firms of any size (2023). No public cloud region serves it: as of early 2025 West Africa was the only world region with no established or announced public cloud region from any of the top five cloud providers.

The rules on where data may sit are permissive: Benin imposes no data localisation requirement on personal or other data (2024). The one boundary proposed so far is around generative AI, where an ASIN legal note of June 2026 recommends barring transfers of administration data to extraterritorial jurisdictions while conceding that residual risks to digital sovereignty and technological dependence remain. Volume is about to rise: a joint ministerial circular of 24 July 2026 requires every state structure to move archive and procedure management onto digital tools.

Energy

Power, not bandwidth, is the constraint on always-on services: firms reported 7.8 electrical outages a month in the 2024 World Bank Enterprise Survey. Electricity reached 57.0 per cent of the population in 2023, split 70.3 per cent urban against 43.7 per cent rural, a gap of 26.6 percentage points that rural electrification investment has been narrowing. Access to Energy is one of Benin's ten worst-scoring IIAG indicators at 22.7 out of 100 in 2023, 40th of 54, and it improved only 4.5 points over the decade.

That shows up wherever a public service meets the grid: most primary schools have no access to computers, and some rural areas have no electricity at all (2023).

Domestic generation is almost entirely non-renewable: renewable sources accounted for 0.26 per cent of domestic electricity output in 2021, and the share has not exceeded 3.4 per cent since 1990. Distributed supply has a policy vehicle behind it, an off-grid clean energy facility combining geospatial planning with deployment subsidies (2020). Energy statistics themselves score below the built environment and natural resources in the 2024 Open Data Inventory.

Technical Capacity

The state is building a security-engineering cadre and has redefined what it is for: ASIN's position is that the information-system security officer's role has moved from managing antivirus and firewalls to strategic advice, and that an officer still doing ordinary IT work is the failure mode the programme exists to prevent (2026). Intake to the certification programme has been opened beyond central government to local authorities, state enterprises and the private sector, so the cadre is being assembled by training people in post rather than by creating a civil-service grade.

The academic pipeline behind it exists without international standing: a dedicated national university of science, technology, engineering and mathematics, UNSTIM, created in 2016. The working developer base it feeds is small and still emerging (2025), and where the state builds anything large it still buys the engineering — the biometric passport renewal application was developed by an external vendor.

Government's own measured readiness sits in the middle band of the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024. A government strategy for public-sector digital skills covers both advanced skills and basic digital literacy, with no results published against it (2025). Capacity is being pushed outward as well as upward: the World Bank delivered 2,050 biometric enrolment terminals in October 2024, equipping registration points rather than only central offices, and the University of Abomey-Calavi trained administrative staff across its faculties before switching document requests onto a single platform in July 2026.

Cybersecurity

Benin published its first national report on the vulnerabilities of Beninese cyberspace at Cotonou on 25 June 2025, recording 878 vulnerabilities over 2021-2024, 23 per cent of them rated critical and 832 password leaks, with incidents traced to outdated software, weak staff awareness and missing patches, with compliance against the state information-system security policy varying widely across the institutions audited, and the public service the sector with most vulnerabilities. That sits beside a score of 91.54 out of 100 on the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index in 2024, the second-highest in Africa.

The institutional stack is real. A national digital-security strategy has run since 2020, under which the country has stood up a national CSIRT, a national public-key infrastructure, a forensic-analysis laboratory and a critical-infrastructure protection policy. Binding law comes from the consolidated Digital Code, whose Article 427 requires every data controller, payment providers included, to notify the supervisory authority and the affected person of a breach without delay. ASIN has given institutional security officers a common risk-analysis method, run a table-top crisis-management exercise with FIRST in March 2025 and trained unit heads of the Republican Police in 2026; Benin was among the African countries covered by Interpol's Carton Rouge 2.0 cybercrime operation, whose results were announced in February 2026.

What none of it yet reaches is the core of government's own estate. Across the financial management system, the treasury single account and the customs, tax, human resources and payroll systems, the 2025 assessment records no governance arrangements for operations covering compliance, security, registers and audit trails; only e-procurement has them, and they are internal and unpublished. Meanwhile more of the state is exposed as public services move online, and ASIN works closely with some forty priority public and private structures (July 2025), and public agents already use generative AI tools on personal accounts outside any formalised framework, which ASIN's legal note calls for censusing and moving to secured arrangements.

Cotonou has turned this into a regional position, hosting the fifth Cyber Africa Forum on 24-25 June 2025, making its case as Africa's next cyber security hotspot and taking the sixth edition on 16-17 November 2026. A club of information-security officers from public and private institutions was constituted on 26 September 2026, and the national digital investigations centre opened complaint points at Porto-Novo, Abomey and Parakou.

DPI

Data Exchange

ASIN set out the conditions of access to Benin's national data exchange in July 2026, six years after the platform was instituted: a body must be registered in the Catalogue des solutions interopérables, must demonstrate data governance covering quality, reliability and lifecycle control, and must run infrastructure compatible with the Xroad-BJ architecture. Exchanges then run under conventions naming the data exchanged, the purposes, the responsibilities of each party and the security measures applied, and a private body must obtain authorisation from the data-protection authority before its first connection.

The platform was instituted by décret n° 2020-209 of 18 March 2020 and runs on UXP, with live platform statistics published at statistiques.xroad.bj (July 2026). ASIN administers it while a Comité national d'interopérabilité supervises it, keeping the supervising body distinct from the operator, and the accompanying Cadre d'interopérabilité sets four levels of interoperability for public bodies and binds private bodies that provide a public service as well as public ones.

What crosses it is uneven. The SECUROUTE application gives the national transport agency, the tax directorate and the traffic police a shared dataset covering vehicle registration, roadworthiness inspection, insurance, tax and safety compliance — the most prominent use of the exchange, and one that has cut the room for fraud (2025). The tax authority exposes IFUONLINE, an API letting other administrations verify the authenticity of a taxpayer's identification number, and the business register and the national cadastre are catalogued as systems connected to the platform. Trade runs on a platform of its own: the foreign-trade single window, operating since 2018 and handed to the government by its builder in July 2023, had carried more than CFAF 900bn in electronic payments.

The World Bank's 2025 assessment records the interoperability framework as extensively used, supported by a data quality framework, monitoring of the uptime of government information systems and guidance for replacing legacy systems; monitoring of the framework's own usage, compliance and benefits is done internally and is not published.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Biometric enrolment in Benin's national register of natural persons has reached close to 99 per cent of the population (May 2026), but enrolment and a usable credential have come apart: a civil-society card drive across nine communes ran into defective fingerprints and RAVIP numbers that did not work among people already enrolled (May 2026), so registration in the database does not guarantee a document that works.

The system rests on Law No. 2017-08 of 19 June 2017, which establishes the personal identification number and the national population register and creates ANIP, and which makes the electronic national identity card compulsory for every Beninese aged 18 and over. Enrolment captures a digital photograph and fingerprints of both hands, with no iris capture. A decree of 26 February 2020 makes the personal identification number mandatory for access to every public service and for data exchange between public bodies, and bars private bodies from using it as a search or database key. ANIP is attached directly to the presidency and responsible for identity management, the national population register and the electoral register, its director general also serving as National Civil Registrar.

Holding the number is close to a condition of economic participation. Unregistered SIM cards were ordered deactivated from 30 April 2025, credit and microfinance institutions must accept ANIP's biometric documents for banking formalities, and the card is required to receive care under the ARCH health-insurance programme. ANIP delivered 10.5 million identification and civil-status services in 2025, 75 per cent of them through digital channels, and waived the fee on "C'est Moi" cards around the April 2026 presidential poll so that voters could still be identified.

Civil registration is the weaker leg. ANIP manages birth, marriage and death records alongside identity, holding them in two central registers, the RNPP and the RNEC, with 2,050 mobile registration terminals donated in 2024 so that health facilities can register births directly, and a one-stop-shop pilot launched in ten public health facilities in August 2025 lets parents receive a child's number by SMS without visiting the town hall. Benin's civil registration score stood at 62.5 out of 100 in 2023, 24th of 54 African states. Pensioners can prove they are alive from a smartphone, by a fingerprint check in a dedicated application, on the finance ministry's announcement of 3 October 2026.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Benin carries 21.4 per cent of the WAEMU's e-money transaction volume but only about 7.5 per cent of the Union's transaction value (2024): money moves often here and in small amounts. Its share of Union volume fell from 22.2 to 21.4 per cent in 2024, on the slowest volume growth in the Union at 11.29 per cent, even as registered merchant acceptance points rose 62 per cent on QR-code deployment. Seven e-money issuing establishments operate in Benin, of 69 across the WAEMU, and 11.65 million active mobile money accounts were counted at the end of 2025, with MTN holding roughly 51 per cent of them.

Benin is one of the eight WAEMU states on the BCEAO's interoperable instant-payment system PI-SPI, opened to the public on 30 September 2025, on which domestic transfers are free to the user. Deployment is partial: four participants were authorised to open the service to the public in Benin at the 30 September 2025 launch, and in June 2026 the central bank extended connection deadlines to 30 September 2026 for banks and e-money issuers and to 30 June 2027 for microfinance institutions.

The state collects digitally far better than it pays. 95 per cent of VAT revenue and 40 per cent of property-tax revenue were collected through digital payments at the end of 2024, and the tax online service portal offers registration, filing and payment. At the end of 2023 none of the beneficiaries of back-to-school bonuses, scholarships, pensions and other social transfers received a digital government-to-person payment; the GBESSOKÉ safety net began monthly mobile-money transfers in September 2025, reaching 20,621 households across twelve pilot communes.

The 2024 WAEMU instruction on payment services requires providers to publish their charges, answer customer complaints within seven working days with escalation to the Banking Commission or a national mediator, and refund unauthorised payments immediately. Users of ATMs and mobile money report recurrent failed transactions in which funds are debited without the transfer completing, with slow or absent reimbursement (July 2025). Proof of an official mission is now given on a mobile application, by location and fingerprint, under the second phase of the missions payment system.

Registries

Benin's third General Business Census found that only 11.7 per cent of the 215,755 enterprises enumerated in 2023-24 were registered in the trade register, and only 14.1 per cent held a tax identification number — the trade-register share up only marginally from 2008, and both still leaving the great majority of firms outside. Registration itself is not the obstacle: the monentreprise.bj platform issues trade register entry, the tax number, the legal notice and the labour declaration digitally, typically within three hours.

Land is thinner. The digital cadastre covers 12 communes, where at least 491,420 parcels had been registered by early 2025, against some nine million parcels nationally, fewer than one per cent of them holding a land title (2025); what exists is published online at cadastre.bj. There is no operational national address register: a national street-naming and building-numbering strategy was approved in April 2026 for rollout first in Cotonou, Abomey-Calavi, Ouidah, Porto-Novo, Sèmè-Podji and Parakou.

Civil registration is where near-universal biometric enrolment fails to carry through. Of roughly 2.5 million births declared between 2021 and 2025, fewer than one million were actually registered, because parents had to make a second journey to an ANIP office to convert a declaration into a record. Moving the desk inside the maternity ward lifted registration to 76.56 per cent across ten pilot maternities over six months, though national generalisation slipped by three to four months into a consolidation phase (July 2026).

The population register doubles as the electoral roll, and 7,834,608 voters were registered for the January 2026 legislative elections against an estimated voting-age population of 7,599,871. The Registre Social Unique was created by decree in September 2023 and widened in June 2024 to households exposed to shocks, notably climatic ones; its procedure manual of that month records more than 300,000 households and requires the identification number to enrol, and it is used to identify beneficiaries for free health-insurance enrolment (January 2026); it collects each household's national identification number as a core field, and the tax register is tied to the same number, with an individual able to obtain a tax identification number within 24 hours by supplying theirs online. A free campaign from 16 to 30 September 2026 issued a first birth certificate to 50,109 children under 14, on the identification agency's count.

Sectoral management information systems

Benin's health information system has leaned on paper to reach private providers: a donor-funded project distributed 4,000 health data registers to private facilities in every region and trained their staff to fill in the national reporting tools that feed DHIS2 (2018-2023). A health-facility geo-registry consolidated the master facility list, though its automatic feed into the national DHIS2 was left unfinished when the project ended (March 2026).

Education has been pushed the other way by directive. A ministerial letter of February 2026 ordered every school director to bring enrolment for all classes up to date on the government's EducMaster platform, on pain of exclusion from paid work on the June 2026 primary-leaving certificate exams, stressing that the platform manages the whole sub-sector and not only certificate entries.

The public service runs a custom-built human resources management system with a self-service portal for employees and managers, and a payroll system linked to it, also custom-built, though the HR system does not use the national identity number as either a primary or a secondary identifier. A decree adopted on 4 March 2026 ends payment of salaries without prior authorisation and runs the pay chain through the integrated HR and payroll system, SIGRHP. Customs and tax each run a commercial off-the-shelf management system, each exchanging data with other government systems both through separate interfaces and through the government service bus, with the two administrations not merged — customs completing its migration from ASYCUDA to a vendor platform at every office in April 2025 — and the tax administration's internal system SIGIBE is catalogued in the national interoperability inventory. A social insurance system providing public sector and other non-health pensions is in use, its pension management system exchanging data with other government systems (2025). Across these core systems the same assessment records no documented governance arrangements for operations covering compliance, security, registers and audit trails.

In the courts, the commercial court of Cotonou made three procedures online-only from 16 February 2026, on a filing and payment platform it opened in 2021, while the e-justice project to link 110 justice sites by a private network was at feasibility-study stage in August 2024.

Policing gained an automated fingerprint and palm-print identification system in September 2025, put into service at the Republican Police's Directorate-General under the West African Police Information System programme with European Union funding.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A joint ministerial circular of 24 July 2026 requires every state structure to move archive and procedure management onto digital tools, and the returns the government claims for it are fiscal and environmental — lower printing, physical-archiving and file-circulation costs and a reduced administrative carbon footprint — rather than better service to the citizen. The government launched a National Administrative Simplification Prize on 12 October 2026, inviting public servants, citizens and firms to propose simpler procedures, digitised procedures and data sharing between administrations among them, with submissions open from 29 October to 12 November.

Benin reported more than 250 public services online at the regional digital summit in Cotonou in November 2025. When the count stood at more than 230, ASIN's director general said that leaves more of the state open to cyber attack, and that ASIN works closely on security with some forty priority structures (July 2025). The World Bank's 2025 assessment records an online public service portal operating at transactional level, universally accessible across channels and designed with citizen and business involvement, but no government mobile app for reaching public services; a social insurance and pension portal in use; a job portal carrying public sector positions alongside other vacancies; and an e-procurement portal that publishes tender notices and contracts but does not publish to the Open Contracting Data Standard and does not exchange data with other government systems; a 2024 evaluation found only 21 of the 757 calls published on it in 2023 had reached the automatic contract stage, and the treasury announced in December 2025 that a new e-Procurement platform replaces it, with no go-live date stated.

On the financial side a custom financial management system covers treasury operations and budget preparation for central government only, a treasury single account is only partially used by ministries, departments and agencies, with no interface linking the financial management system to central bank systems, and a debt management system covers both foreign and domestic debt, with no public investment management system at all.

Coordination is the gap that assessment names: Benin has an established government entity focused on GovTech and digital transformation, but no coordination body such as a steering committee or council leading GovTech initiatives, and no entity monitoring and reporting digital spending across the whole of government.

Putting a service online has not always reached the bottleneck it was aimed at: residence certificates applied for online still depend on a neighbourhood or village chief obtaining a code from ANIP's platform, which many chiefs struggle to get (April 2025). Benin scored 0.4264 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, while Public Administration was its most improved IIAG sub-category over 2014-2023, up 17.6 points to 69.3 out of 100 and 7th of 54. The national police issues loss certificates only online from 1 October 2026, with electronic payment.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The financial spine of the Beninese state stops at the centre: the financial management information system covers treasury operations and budget preparation for central government only (2025), so what the 77 communes run on is not part of it. Nor do they have the foundational registers a local administration works from. No operational national address register exists: a strategy to standardise street naming and building numbering was approved by the Council of Ministers in April 2026, to begin in Cotonou, Abomey-Calavi, Ouidah, Porto-Novo, Sèmè-Podji and Parakou, and the country still relies on informal landmarks and post-office boxes. The digital cadastre was deployed in 12 communes, covering more than 491,000 registered parcels, with extension to the whole country the next step (2025).

Where national platforms do reach the communal tier they reach it as delivery channels rather than as local capability. The GBESSOKÉ social safety net began monthly electronic cash transfers by mobile money in September 2025, reaching 20,621 beneficiaries, 85 per cent of them women, across twelve pilot communes, with beneficiaries issued dedicated SIM cards, and is to extend to all 77 communes. Civil registration runs the same way: e-SIRCEV, launched in 2019, assigns a unique identification number at birth through the registration centres, a national system operated locally rather than a communal one. A commune can build its own channel: Adjarra put a citizen complaints app, Döton, on the app store in February 2025, with a cell at the town hall handling what comes in.

The limit of that model shows where a national service still depends on a local official. Putting residence-certificate applications online has not removed the bottleneck: issuance still depends on a neighbourhood or village chief obtaining a code from ANIP's platform, which many chiefs struggle to get (April 2025). Access to civil-status records remains a live local grievance, with communal authorities in Godomey holding an open dialogue with residents about it in June 2026. One thing is being built deliberately across the tiers: intake to the information-security officer certification programme has been opened beyond central government to local authorities, state enterprises and the private sector (August 2026).

A communes-association project put networked cash-desk software at single revenue windows in 12 communes in 2019-20. The association's digital commission was still discussing the digitisation of commune revenue collection in June 2025, with connectivity named as the first need.

A development bank recorded 187 authorities, ministries, the presidency and prefectures, connected in one administrative network by May 2023, with every municipality to follow. The government's 2025 bond report counts 12 more town halls using the network's services in 2024.

Rural digital data capture

A ministerial directive of February 2026 requires every school director in Benin to bring enrolment for all classes up to date on the government's EducMaster platform, on pain of exclusion from paid work on the primary-leaving certificate exams. It is an obligation placed on schools where most have no computers and where electricity is the exception.

Capture has moved further in the health system, and through health facilities rather than local government offices. In October 2024 the World Bank donated 2,050 mobile registration terminals meant to let health facilities in every district register births directly into the national population and civil status registers, and in August 2025 the identification agency opened a one-stop-shop pilot in public health facilities, including hospitals serving rural catchments at Natitingou, Djougou and Borgou-Alibori, under which parents receive their child's identification number by SMS without visiting the town hall. Clinical reporting has moved less: the response to missing private-facility data was to distribute 4,000 health data registers and train staff to fill in the national reporting tools (2018-2023). Land data is worse served still: the digital cadastre reaches only 12 communes (2025).

The rural economy this data describes has barely moved. Benin's Rural Economy sub-category in the Ibrahim Index scored 63.9 out of 100 in 2023, 23rd of 54 and up only 2.4 points over the decade, one of the smallest gains among its improving sub-categories. Within it, rural market access is the only measure to have fallen over 2014-2023, down 9.3 points to 37.8 and 30th of 54, against rural land and water access at 75.6 and rural representation and participation at 76.9.

Technology

AI

Artificial intelligence reached the field in Benin before it reached the administration. A malaria programme combining artificial intelligence, drones and geospatial mapping, worth US$2.3m and funded by Japan, was launched in June 2026. A year earlier the digital agency ASIN and IIDiA launched a Gates Foundation-supported regional lab whose first project is a voice-to-voice artificial intelligence model in Fon, a national language, with a prototype due within nine months (June 2025).

The policy frame is older than either. The National Artificial Intelligence and Big Data Strategy 2023-2027 was adopted in January 2023, and it is where the compute question sits: the strategy sets out plans to equip the national data centre with cloud and AI-as-a-service capability for hosting public-sector systems. That is a plan for the hosting layer, not a hosting layer in place, and the distinction matters more here than in most chapters, because everything else the strategy proposes runs on it.

Governance arrived in 2026, and it arrived from the operational side rather than the legislative one. ASIN issued a legal note on the use of generative artificial intelligence tools by public agents across the administration in June 2026, prompted by agents already using such tools on personal accounts outside any formalised framework. Beyond the border, Benin adopted shared AI governance guidelines with Burkina Faso, Côte d'Ivoire, Guinea, Mali and Senegal, submitted to the UN Global AI Dialogue (July 2026), and the ECOWAS digital roadmap of January 2026 sets a regional AI governance framework for West Africa as a target. The digital agency's bulletin of September 2026 called for AI-specific rules on governance, liability and compliance, naming no legal vehicle or timetable.

ICT Industry

The state buys in its identity technology: the biometric passport renewal app, the identity front door for citizens abroad, was built by the vendor Seamfix on its own GovSmart platform (December 2025). The domestic bid is narrower and more recent. Benin has chosen cyber security start-ups rather than procurement alone as its route to capability in that field (April 2025), and is making its case as Africa's next cyber security hotspot through the Cyber Africa Forum (June 2025).

Two conditions sit under any of it. Most firms enumerated in the 2023-24 general business census were outside the trade register, so the formal base a technology sector would be counted within is thin, and firms report frequent electrical outages, which constrains any always-on service built domestically (2024).

Innovation ecosystem

The state agency now runs an incubator itself. Cyber Incub, a cyber-security-only start-up incubator run by ASIN and ADPME with Luxembourg's support through its BeDigital programme, has been taking ten teams through incubation at Abomey-Calavi since November 2025, with 10 million FCFA each due to the three most promising (April 2026). Alongside it, ASIN's HackerLab competition has drawn more than 500 entrants (2025), and several technology hubs operate alongside the state-backed Sèmè City campus (2024).

What that machinery is not doing is producing a broad base of financed firms. The large funding rounds go to foreign-led e-mobility and ride-hailing ventures, while locally founded start-ups raise smaller or undisclosed sums (2025), and the developer community it draws on remains small. Benin ranked 119th on WIPO's Global Innovation Index in 2024, in the bottom quartile.

The government's own instruments have the shape of a system without the evidence of one working. There is a policy to support GovTech start-ups and financing for start-up and SME innovation, but no procurement policy reserving or prioritising bids for start-ups and small firms — so the state supports the sector as a funder without using its own purchasing to do it — and no results are published on the support given (2025). The pattern repeats inside the administration: an established government entity for public sector innovation and a strategy behind it, and collaboration with the private sector recorded as a standing mechanism rather than a one-off, with nothing published on what either has produced (2025).

External money is arriving for specific institutions rather than for the sector at large, including a timbuktoo innovation lab at the University of Abomey-Calavi with prototyping labs and incubation attached.

Capacity

Literacy

Benin's schooling is now judged better than it is attended: assessed education quality rose 23.0 points over 2014-2023 to rank seventh of 54 African countries, one of the country's ten most improved governance indicators, while over the same decade enrolment and completion both fell, to 34th and 30th of 54 respectively.

Human Resources in Education held a stronger position, 31st of 54, but it fell too, by 15.9 points across the decade. The improvement in judged quality is therefore sitting on top of a system reaching fewer children, taught with thinner inputs than it had ten years earlier.

On digital literacy the state's provision is at least free at the point of use: the government offers digital skills programmes to citizens and to schools at no charge (2025). It has also begun building around the reading barrier rather than only through it — a Fon-language voice artificial intelligence model under development is meant to let speakers who do not read, or do not use French, reach digital services in their mother tongue (June 2025).

The classroom itself remains largely off the system while the administration above it moves online. In rural primary schools in Atacora and Atlantique departments, attendance call registers and in-class monitoring are still run on paper (2026). At the other end of the education system, from 31 July 2026 the Université d'Abomey-Calavi requires degree certificates, transcripts, enrolment certificates and diploma duplicates to be requested through an online platform.

Training and skills

Benin is assembling a state cyber security officer corps to a stated headcount: the target is 100 qualified information-system security officers by the end of 2026, and the August 2026 cohort took the country to roughly 85 trained. That cohort was 25 officers, drawn from more than 200 applications, on a four-week certifying course opened in Cotonou on 3 August 2026 teaching Certified Ethical Hacker and ISO 27001, with practical work at the national Cyber Range. Intake has been opened beyond central government to local authorities, state enterprises and the private sector, and the programme is presented as part of implementing the national digital security strategy, building the cadre by training people in post rather than by creating a civil-service grade.

ASIN's other training runs wide of that cadre. It trained 300 unit heads of the Republican Police in cyber security and sensitive-data protection in June 2026, ran a table-top crisis-management simulation in March 2025 with FIRST, the global incident response forum, and runs a HackerLab competition alongside the Cyber Africa Forum that has drawn more than 500 entrants (2025).

The pipeline behind it includes a dedicated national university of science, technology, engineering and mathematics, UNSTIM, created in 2016 to train technical cadres, and the computing institute of the University of Abomey-Calavi, IFRI, which offers professional bachelor's and master's degrees in software engineering, computer security and information systems and networks, at a university of 62,175 students in 2023-2024. The state also runs a job portal reachable across channels, handling registration, search and application online and carrying public sector vacancies (2025), designed without involving the people who use it.

A government digital skills strategy for the public sector covers both advanced skills and basic digital literacy (2025). Beyond it sit commitments rather than programmes: the Cotonou Declaration of November 2025 set targets of basic digital skills for 20 million people and digital jobs or entrepreneurship for 2 million young people and women, and called on signatories to adopt national digital compacts by 2028, and the 2026–2033 programme put to voters by the Wadagni–Talata ticket promises mass training in artificial intelligence, data science and robotics through Sèmè City.

Research institutions

The largest identifiable addition to Benin's research capacity is externally funded: UNDP is putting about USD 2.8 million over 2022-2026 into a timbuktoo innovation lab at the University of Abomey-Calavi, adding a digital innovation and technology research module with prototyping labs, technology incubation and entrepreneurship support.

It lands on a teaching base that includes a dedicated national university of science, technology, engineering and mathematics, UNSTIM, created in 2016 — but one whose output does not yet register internationally: Benin ranked 119th on WIPO's Global Innovation Index in 2024, in the bottom quartile.

Inclusion

Access to services

Benin scores 60.3 out of 100 on equal access to public services, seventh of 54 African states and 3.4 points up over the decade (2023). Access increasingly runs through the identity credential: near-universal enrolment has made the national identification number the entry key to services well beyond government, from microcredit to a telephone subscription (2025), and the biometric card is required to receive care under the ARCH health-insurance scheme (2021).

Being in the register is not the same as holding a usable credential. A free-card drive across nine communes ran into defective fingerprints and non-working registration numbers among people already enrolled (May 2026). Cost bites too: ANIP waived the card fee around the April 2026 presidential poll and held its channels open until voting morning. An offline route survives where one has been built — the electoral platforms carry a USSD line for people with no internet access (2025) — but where the credential is missing altogether the exclusion is absolute: undocumented displaced people in the north cannot open mobile money accounts, so the World Food Programme distributes access codes to get cash assistance to them (2023), and 16,463 recognised refugees held no valid identity card and about 12,400 asylum-seekers awaited registration at end June 2026, as UNHCR and the authorities work on their biometric integration into the national register. The law, adopted on 13 April 2017, ties rights in health, education, employment, communication and transport to an equal-opportunity card. Law No. 2017-06 obliges private financial providers to accommodate persons with disabilities, though a government workshop in Cotonou in August 2024 was convened as a first stocktaking of exclusion still observed in the sector.

Complaint channels have multiplied without published caseloads: a corruption-reporting platform and free line 155 opened in December 2022, the national ombudsman opened online referral in November 2023, having received 697 complaints in 2022, and the treasury takes complaints by telephone, e-mail, web form and at a counter (2025).

The counter where cash meets the digital system is being withdrawn. The number of mobile-money distributors in Benin fell by 29.69 per cent in a single year, which the BCEAO links to distributors pulling out as commissions were cut and to the closure of inactive points, within a 5.23 per cent contraction in service points across the Union (2024). Government payment has moved the other way, slowly: social transfers were still not being paid digitally at the end of 2023, and the GBESSOKÉ safety net began mobile-money transfers in twelve pilot communes in September 2025.

The cash-out network and the merchant acceptance network moved in opposite directions in the same year: the counter where cash is exchanged is being withdrawn as the till is being wired.

Digital divides

Benin has enrolled close to the whole population in its biometric register, but the digital minister acknowledged a persistent digital divide as the strategic vision for 2031 was drafted (February 2026).

Beneath the services sits the physical divide. Urban households are considerably more likely than rural ones to have an electricity connection (2023), and internet use is still a minority of the population (2023), so the number of people who can reach a service online is a good deal smaller than the number the register holds. On the composite measure of internet and computer access Benin sits in the middle of the African field, having gained heavily over the decade to 2023 — a fast-closing gap on the continent and a wide one at home. The World Bank-financed PITN2R, launched in December 2020 at US$47.2m over five years, is to bring broadband to 2,128 villages in Alibori, Borgou, Donga, Atacora and Collines, and 43 community digital points and 43 free WiFi hotspots were in service by April 2021; no coverage result is published for either.

Language and skills are treated as divides in their own right. The voice artificial intelligence model in Fon, whose development began in June 2025, is meant to let speakers who do not read, or do not use French, reach digital services in their mother tongue. The government offers digital skills programmes to citizens and schools free of charge (2025) and has set up a digital innovation and inclusion lab under ASIN, against a connectivity and skills gap it accepts leaves digital public services only partly reachable (2025).

Data

National statistics

Two of the five survey types the World Bank tracks went entirely unsupplied in Benin over the ten years to 2023: no agricultural survey and no business or establishment survey were run in that period, and data sources is the weakest of the statistical system's five pillars, in the 20-49 per cent band against data use above 89 per cent, data products in the 70-89 per cent band, and data services and data infrastructure both between 50 and 69 per cent (2023). The state is markedly better at using statistics than at collecting them.

The enumeration base is in better order. A population census and an agricultural census were both run within the ten years to 2023, while the business census fell outside that window, and household and health surveys were each conducted three or more times over the same period, with two labour force surveys. The enterprise gap has since been addressed on the census side, with INStaD's third general business census in the field in 2023-24. Mapping for the fifth population and housing census began in the remaining 74 communes on 19 March 2024 after a three-commune pilot; no enumeration result is held.

The office itself is getting stronger: capacity of the statistical system rose 14.1 points over 2014-2023, ranking Benin 19th of 54 African countries. Administrative data is starting to feed official statistics: INStaD's civil-status yearbook for 2024 counts 468,570 births registered, compiled from ANIP's digital civil-status platform. It cannot yet substitute for survey collection, though. Civil registration remains incomplete, the great majority of enumerated enterprises sit outside both the trade register and the tax register, and private health facilities needed paper registers and staff training before their data reached the national health information system (2023).

Where the state does measure its own performance, it does so through the budget: the financial management information system captures expenditure linked to the Sustainable Development Goals extensively, and non-financial performance indicators for most government programmes and projects (2025).

Open data

Benin discloses public records comparatively well, 11th of 54 African countries in 2023 and up 8.2 points over the decade, yet reaching those records is among its ten worst-scoring governance indicators, 34th of 54 despite a 9.6-point decade improvement. Publication is not the constraint; access is.

What is published best is financial and agricultural. Balance of payments, banking and monetary statistics, and agriculture and land use each score 7 out of 10 for coverage and openness in 2024, while government finance statistics are the weakest of all 22 categories at 3 out of 10, with national accounts at 4.5 and trade and labour at 5. The state publishes least well on its own money. Social coverage sits in between — education facilities and outcomes at 6.5, population and gender statistics at 5.5, health facilities at 5, health outcomes at 4.5 and crime at 4 — as does the environment, with energy at 4.5, pollution at 5, the built environment at 5.5 and natural resources at 6 (2024).

Across the 22 categories assessed in 2024, the scores run from 3 to 7 out of 10 and average 5.4, and none reaches 7.5. The ceiling is low across the board.

The open data portal is refreshed weekly to daily but carries only basic information and datasets, and is updated mostly by hand rather than dynamically through APIs (2025). The right to ask for what is not published exists on paper: right-to-information legislation is in force, makes information available digitally, and has an entity monitoring its implementation, but nothing is published on requests received, granted or refused. The same pattern runs through the systems themselves — monitoring of the interoperability framework's usage, compliance and benefits is done internally and not published, and the e-procurement portal publishes tender notices and contracts but not to the Open Contracting Data Standard (2025).

Of the sixteen transparency measures in the 2025 GovTech assessment, exactly one records something actually published — the service standards attached to citizen feedback. Twelve record no publication at all, and three record reporting that exists but is kept internal.

Use of satellite data

A US$2.3m malaria programme funded by Japan combines artificial intelligence, drones and geospatial mapping to target mosquito breeding sites (June 2026). Beyond that donor-funded project, no national position on Earth observation or geospatial data use — an agency, a receiving facility, a policy — was established as at August 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

American aid money reaches Benin's health data through implementing contractors, and what it buys is not always digital: a USAID-funded project supplied private health facilities with 4,000 health data registers and trained their staff to report into the national health information system (2018-2023).

China activities

Benin's fibre backbone was built on Chinese concessional credit. China Eximbank signed a CNY 496 million (about USD 89 million) government concessional loan on 7 April 2015 for the first phase of the National Broadband Network Project, on 20-year maturity with a seven-year grace period at 2 per cent interest, financing a Huawei contract with Benin Telecom to rehabilitate the Cotonou-Malanville backbone and build a metropolitan loop in Cotonou.

The second phase, densifying that network, again runs on a China Eximbank concessional loan, with the Agence du Numerique as implementing agency (2022).

Eleven distinct financiers appear across the external commitments to Benin's digital sector, and China Eximbank stands among the largest by value committed on the strength of these two loans alone.

EU activities

European money sits behind Benin's newest police biometric system: the automated fingerprint identification system inaugurated on 30 September 2025 connects to the ECOWAS SIPAO police data-exchange network, which is EU-funded and implemented by Interpol.

Germany funds two of the standing programmes. BMZ pays for BenInnovation, a EUR 6.5 million programme running from 2022 to 2026 on the structuring of the digital sector, behind the government's stated goal of making Benin the digital platform of West Africa, and a further EUR 9 million over the same four years for micro, small and medium-sized enterprises, where digitalisation skills sit among the gaps it addresses alongside business planning, product development and marketing.

Smaller European positions run through national development agencies rather than Brussels. Luxembourg's LuxDev backs Cyber Incub, the cybersecurity-only start-up incubator run by ASIN and ADPME (April 2026), and Belgium's Enabel ran DigiBoost, a grant and technical support programme for the organisations that support digital startups and small firms, from 2019 to 2023.

Gulf/UAE activities

One Gulf instrument is held and it has no digital subject. A UAE minister of state met President Talon in Cotonou on 22 March 2023 and signed a memorandum of understanding with the Beninese foreign minister to promote technical collaboration between the two foreign ministries. No Gulf infrastructure, operator holding, data-centre commitment or financing naming Benin is on the record.

India activities

India's position rests on a single day of signatures and nothing since. The joint statement of President Kovind's state visit of 28 to 30 July 2019 records four signed instruments - cultural exchange, telemedicine and tele-education, visa exemption, and export-credit and investment-insurance cooperation - and a US$100 million Indian line of credit. The telemedicine and tele-education memorandum is the digital limb; no infrastructure, platform deployment or later agreement is on the record, and nothing reports what was done under it.

Digital sovereignty

Benin's digital agency has written the exit terms it wants from outside suppliers before any law requires them: ASIN's June 2026 legal note on generative AI in the administration calls for data-processing agreements, a ban on using administration data to train models, reversibility and full restitution of data, a bar on transfers to jurisdictions exposed to the US Cloud Act or FISA, sovereign hosting on national territory or at an equivalent level of protection, and diversification of suppliers to limit technological dependence. No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026; the 2026-2033 programme of the Wadagni–Talata ticket promises a data-localisation law.

The national data centre at Abomey-Calavi, 300 square metres, is run by a state-owned telecommunications company, and its redundancy site, under a World Bank-funded feasibility study launched in March 2026, need not be in Benin but may be in another country of the region. The exchange layer is run the same way: ASIN administers the national data exchange while a national interoperability committee supervises it.

Some of the state's software runs on vendors' platforms. Seamfix built the biometric passport renewal application on its own GovSmart platform (December 2025), and the state deposit fund CDC Bénin tendered in May 2026 to link its directory to Microsoft Entra ID and harden its Microsoft 365 estate. ASIN's stated answer is spread rather than self-sufficiency: its director general described Benin's partners in 2024 as a portfolio spanning Estonia, Rwanda, China and France, chosen to avoid dependence on any one. Whether the state holds the source code for the passport renewal platform, or can exit its operating contract, was not on record as at September 2026.

Across borders, Benin is one of the three states in Smart Africa's cross-border digital-identity pilot with Rwanda and Ghana, whose technical mission in Kigali in April 2026 tested PKI trust chains and API contracts between the three.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	**2026-10-18**
COMPILED	By Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/BEN/BEN-status-2026-10-18.pdf
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